seeing this trend, this team needs to find the root of the unplanned work and get rid of it. If they must complete it, then they should estimate it and plan for it like everything else in the work stream.

3.3.3. Measuring task movement; recidivism and workflow

The final piece of data to add to this chart is the movement of tasks through your team's workflow. This data gives you great insight into the health of your team by checking how tasks move through the workflow.

For this we'll look at recidivism, which is the measurement of tasks as they move backward in the predefined workflow. If a task moves from development to QA, fails validation, and moves back to development, this would increase the recidivism rate.

Spikes in this data point can indicate potential problems:

- There's a communication gap somewhere on the team.
- Completion criteria (a.k.a. done) are not defined clearly to everyone on the team.
- Tasks are being rushed, usually due to pressure to hit a release date.

If the number of tasks that move backward isn't spiking but is consistently high, then you have an unhealthy amount of churn happening on your team that should be addressed.

Figure 3.12 adds this data point to the charts you've been looking at so far in this chapter.

Figure 3.12. An example of all the data we have so far